

The AI Freelancer Stack: 2026 Playbook

AI ToolKit Digital Product

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The AI Freelancer Stack: 2026 Playbook

A 5-function system, 30-day rollout, and 40+ copy-paste prompts for running a one-person business on AI.

By AI ToolKit - Updated July 2026

What this is

Most freelancers drown in tool subscriptions. You bought ChatGPT, then Jasper, then Copy.ai, then three more - and you're still not sure which one writes the cold email, which one writes the proposal, and which one is just a \$40/month bookmark.

This playbook is the operating manual we wish we had when we started freelancing with AI. It collapses 500+ AI tools into 5 functions a freelancer actually performs, picks the best tool for each, and ships you a 30-day rollout plus the exact prompts that pay for it in week one.

You will get:

The 5-Function Freelancer Stack (Land -> Deliver -> Bill -> Grow -> Reuse)

Tool picks with verified 2026 pricing for each function

A 30-Day Rollout Plan you can print and follow

40+ copy-paste prompts organized by job-to-be-done

A Freelancer Stack Audit worksheet (PDF fillable)

A Pricing Calculator with the exact rates to charge for AI-assisted work

A Proposal Template (Copy.ai prompt + fill-in-the-blank version)

The "Don't AI This Yet" list (the 7 things that hurt your reputation if you let a model touch them)

Who this is for

New freelancers (0-12 months) who want a stack they won't outgrow in 6 months

Established solopreneurs stuck with too many subscriptions and no system

Coaches and consultants running a one-person practice

Agency-of-one operators (designer + dev + marketer) who wear five hats

If you bill hourly, this playbook pays for itself the first time you replace 2 hours of grunt work with a 5-minute prompt.

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1. Why Freelancers Need a Stack, Not a Tool

The mistake most freelancers make in 2026 is buying tools in the same order they read about them:

Subscribe to ChatGPT Plus (\$20/mo) "for research"

See a Copy.ai ad, sign up for the \$49 Pro tier

Read a Synthesia case study, drop \$89/mo for an avatar

Hear about AdCreative.ai on a podcast, add \$59/mo

Get a Speechify annual plan because the Black Friday deal was good

Six months later you're at \$237/month, you still wrote your last proposal in Google Docs, and you don't remember which tool is supposed to do what.

A stack is a system. You assign one tool to each function, you don't double-pay, and you know which button to press when a new lead lands. This playbook builds that.

The two tests every tool must pass

Before we put any tool in the stack, it has to pass two tests:

Job test - Does it do one job we need done, better than the free alternative?

Economics test - Will it pay for itself in month 1, or month 2 at the latest?

If a tool fails either test, it doesn't go in the stack. Period.

2. The 5-Function Freelancer Stack

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LAND

Total recommended stack cost: \$60-90/month (vs. \$200-300 for an undisciplined tool pile).

The detailed pick for each function, with verified 2026 pricing, is in sections 3-7.

3. Function 1 - Land Clients (writing + outreach)

Job: Turn cold leads into signed contracts. You need:

- Cold email sequences that don't sound like cold email
- LinkedIn DMs that earn a reply
- Proposals that close above \$5k
- Follow-up messages that don't feel like nagging

Tool pick: Copy.ai (recommended) - or Writesonic on a budget.

Why Copy.ai for landing work

Has dedicated templates for cold email, follow-up, LinkedIn outreach, and proposals

Workflows let you build a 5-step sequence once, then re-run it for every new lead

Brand voice memory means your second email sounds like the first

2026 Chat tier is \$24/mo annual (\$29 monthly) - Pro tier \$49/mo annual (was \$49/mo) - see Appendix for the latest

When to swap in Writesonic

If you write more SEO blog content for your own site than you do client outreach, Writesonic's SEO mode + bulk writer is a better fit. Bulk-generate 10 article briefs in one workflow. 2026: Standard is \$20/mo annual, Professional \$99/mo annual.

Cold email prompt (Copy.ai)

You are a freelance [YOUR ROLE, e.g. "brand designer"] writing a 4-email cold

outreach

Constraints:

- Email 1: 60-90 words. One specific observation about their work, no flattery.
- Email 2 (sent 4 days later, no reply): 50-70 words. Share a 1-paragraph
- Email 3 (sent 7 days later, no reply): 30-50 words. "Closing the loop" tone.
- Email 4 (sent 10 days later, no reply): 25-40 words. Final breakup email.

Tone: direct, specific, no "I hope this email finds you well."

For each email, output: subject line, preview text, body.

Proposal prompt (Copy.ai)

Write a freelance project proposal for [CLIENT NAME] based on these notes:

DISCOVERY CALL NOTES:

- Client pain: [paste 3-5 bullet points]
- Desired outcome: [1 sentence]
- Budget they hinted at: \$[X]
- Timeline they mentioned: [X weeks]
- Decision-maker: [name, title]

MY POSITIONING:

- I help [AUDIENCE] achieve [OUTCOME] via [METHOD].
- Past work: [paste 2 relevant wins with metrics]

Deliver a 1-page proposal in this structure:

1. "Here's what I heard" (3 bullets - proof you listened)
2. "What I'd do" (3-5 phases, each with a deliverable)
3. "Investment" (3 pricing tiers: Starter, Standard, Premium)
4. "Timeline" (table)
5. "Next step" (single CTA: book a 30-min scope call)

Tone: confident, not salesy. No exclamation points. No "I'd love to."

LinkedIn DM prompt

Write a 4-message LinkedIn outreach sequence for a freelance [ROLE] targeting

Constraints:

- Connection request note: 280 characters max. Reference a specific post or

- DM #1 (after they accept): 50-80 words. One specific observation, one question.
- DM #2 (3-4 days later, no reply): 40-60 words. Share a relevant case study in 2
- DM #3 (7 days later, no reply): 30-40 words. "Should I assume the timing's c

Avoid: "Hope you're well," "Circle back," "Synergy," "Touch base."

4. Function 2 - Deliver Work (research, drafting, design, video)

Job: Produce the actual client deliverable. For most freelancers this is some mix of:

- Research (market, audience, competitors)
- Long-form writing (articles, reports, scripts)
- Visual design (social graphics, decks, mockups)
- Short-form video (Reels, TikTok, ads)

Tool picks:

- Canva for design and decks (Pro tier)
- Synthesia for video (no camera needed)
- Speechify for voice (narration, audio versions)
- ChatGPT or Claude for research and long-form (free tier is fine for most freelancers)

The 80/20 of design: Canva

You will produce 80% of your visual work in Canva. Pro is \$15/mo monthly, \$120/yr annual - and unlocks:

- Brand kit (your logo, colors, fonts auto-applied)
- Background remover
- 100M+ stock photos and videos
- Magic Resize (one design -> 7 sizes)
- Content Scheduler (post directly to 8 platforms)

For decks specifically, Canva's presentation mode is now competitive with Google Slides + Beautiful.ai for clients who don't need heavy data viz.

When you need video: Synthesia

If the deliverable is a 60-second product explainer, a course intro, or a LinkedIn video that doesn't show your face, Synthesia at \$29/mo (Starter) gives you 10 minutes of video/month with 230+ AI avatars in 140+ languages. \$89/mo Creator plan doubles the minutes and unlocks custom avatars.

For client work: use Synthesia to draft a v0 of the video, get client feedback, then re-render. Cuts the round-trip from 3 weeks to 3 days.

Voice narration: Speechify

If the deliverable is an audio version of a blog post, a podcast intro, or a YouTube voiceover and you don't want to record, Speechify's AI voice studio at \$139/yr is competitive. The Studio tier at \$24/mo gives you commercial-use voices for client work - important, because the free tier is personal-use only.

Research prompt (use with ChatGPT or Claude)

You are a research analyst for a freelance project. I'm a [YOUR ROLE] working

with [C

I need:

1. Five recent (last 12 months) developments in [INDUSTRY] that affect my
2. Three direct competitors of [CLIENT] and how they position against this
3. Two contrarian takes - what smart practitioners are saying is **wrong** about
4. One specific stat or data point I can cite (with source URL).
5. A 200-word "State of the Market" summary I can use as a section opener in

client's p

trend.

this trend

the deliver

Cite your sources. If you don't know, say "I don't know" - don't make it up.

5. Function 3 - Bill and Get Paid (invoicing, contracts, expense tracking)

Job: Get paid on time, with airtight contracts, and without a bookkeeper.

Tool picks (all free or under \$20/mo):

Bonsai (\$17/mo Solo) - proposals, contracts, invoicing, time tracking, taxes, all in one

Wave (free) - invoicing + accounting for sole proprietors

Stripe (free + 2.9% per transaction) - payment processing

Google Workspace (\$7/mo Starter) - email + drive + docs on a custom domain

Recommendation: Bonsai if you bill >\$3k/month, Wave if you bill less

Bonsai's contract templates alone are worth \$17/mo - they cover scope creep, late payment, and IP ownership in plain English. Wave is unbeatable for pure invoicing if you have a simple LLC.

Late-payment email prompt

Write a 3-email late-payment sequence for an outstanding invoice.

Invoice details:

- Client: [NAME]
- Project: [NAME]
- Amount due: \$[X]
- Original due date: [DATE]
- Days overdue: [N]

Email 1 (1-7 days overdue): friendly reminder, 40-60 words, attach invoice

Email

Tone: professional, not apologetic. Never "just checking in."

6. Function 4 - Grow a Reputation (LinkedIn, newsletter, referrals)

Job: Turn completed projects into inbound leads. Most freelancers underinvest here because the work is invisible until it isn't.

Tool picks:

- Copy.ai for LinkedIn post drafts (same tool as Function 1)
- Canva for LinkedIn carousel graphics
- Speechify for audio versions of posts (LinkedIn now prioritizes native video)
- Buttondown or beehiiv (free tier) for newsletter

LinkedIn carousel prompt

Write a 7-slide LinkedIn carousel on [TOPIC] for a freelance [ROLE].

Target reader: [AUDIENCE]

Goal

Slide 1 (Cover): 8-10 words max. Pattern interrupt + benefit.

Slide

For each slide, give: a headline, 2-3 supporting bullet points, and a

sugge

Newsletter issue prompt

Write a 600-word newsletter issue on [TOPIC] for a freelance [ROLE]

Sections:

- "One thing I learned this week" (200 words, personal + tactical)
- "A resource worth 5 minutes" (150 words, link to a tool or article)
- "A question I'm sitting with" (150 words, invite replies)
- "If you only do one thing this week" (100 words, single specific action)

Voice: first person, conversational, short sentences. No "Hey fam," no

7. Function 5 - Reuse Everything (repurpose, SOPs, productized offers)

Job: Turn one project into five assets and one offer. This is the function that turns a freelancer into a business.

Tool picks:

- Copy.ai for repurposing long-form -> social
- Canva for repurposing graphics -> carousels -> thumbnails
- Gumroad (free) for the productized offer
- Notion (free) for SOP storage

Repurposing prompt

Take this [BLOG POST / CASE STUDY / PODCAST TRANSCRIPT] and produce 10

1. 5 LinkedIn posts (different hooks, same core insight)
2. 3 Twitter/X threads (7 tweets each, hook-first)
3. 1 newsletter issue (600 words)
4. 1 YouTube Shorts script (45-60 seconds, hook in first 3 seconds)
5. 1 Instagram carousel outline (7 slides)
6. 1 lead magnet title + 3-bullet promise
7. 1 cold email pitch to promote the lead magnet
8. 1 podcast guest pitch email
9. 3 quote graphics (text + suggested Canva layout)
10. 1 sales page outline (problem -> solution -> proof -> offer -> CTA)

Keep the core insight consistent. Vary the format and the entry hook.

SOP prompt (for your own operations)

You are an operations consultant. I'm a freelance [ROLE] and I want to

Inputs:

- Task: [TASK NAME]
- Tools used: [LIST]
- Trigger: [WHAT STARTS THIS TASK]
- Output: [WHAT THE CLIENT GETS]
- Time to complete: [N hours]

Write a Standard Operating Procedure with:

- Goal (1 sentence)
- Inputs checklist
- Step-by-step instructions (numbered, each step one action)
- Decision points (if X, do Y; if Z, do W)
- Output checklist
- Common mistakes and how to fix them
- Estimated time per step

Format: ready to paste into Notion.

8. The 30-Day Rollout Plan

Day 1-3: Audit and unsubscribe

Print the Stack Audit worksheet (page 30). List every AI tool you currently pay for. For each, answer:

- Which of the 5 functions does it serve?
- What's the cheapest alternative in that function?
- When did I last use it for a paid deliverable?

Unsubscribe from anything that fails the Job test (section 1) or that you haven't used in 30 days. Save the receipts.

Day 4-7: Pick your stack

For each of the 5 functions, pick ONE primary tool using the recommendations in sections 3-7. Set up billing. Total monthly cost should land between \$60-90.

Day 8-14: Build your prompts

For each function, save the prompts from this playbook into a "Prompt Library" Notion page. Customize them with your role, voice, and offer. Test each prompt on a real past project before going live.

Day 15-21: Test on a real client

Pick one active (or upcoming) project. Use ONLY the new stack for:

- The proposal (Function 1)
- One deliverable (Function 2)
- The invoice (Function 3)

Track time saved vs. your last similar project. Goal: 30%+ time saved on at least one function.

Day 22-30: Repurpose and document

Take the deliverable from Day 15-21 and run it through the Function 5 repurposing prompt. Generate 3-5 assets. Write one SOP for the part of the work you most want to outsource.

By Day 30, you should have:

- A stack of 5-7 tools you actually use
- A prompt library tuned to your voice
- One SOP ready to hand to a subcontractor
- A week's worth of repurposed content in the bank

9. The "Don't AI This Yet" List

These are the 7 things that will hurt your reputation if you let a model touch them without heavy editing:

Your pricing in a proposal. Always set your own price. AI will lowball you.

A client's confidential data. Never paste unredacted client docs into a public model.

Anything that will be legally binding. Contracts, NDAs, SOWs - use Bonsai templates, not raw AI.

Personal health, medical, or financial advice to a client. Refer them to a pro.

The first draft of a reference or testimonial request. It reads as a template - and they know.

A "personal" apology email. A model can't feel sorry. The asymmetry is obvious.

Anything that names a specific person at a client organization without their consent (e.g., a case study). Get the OK first.

10. Pricing Calculator - What to Charge for AI-Assisted Work

The wrong question: "Should I charge less because AI is faster?"

The right question: "Am I charging for time, or for outcome?"

If you charge for time, AI will eat your margins. Charge for outcome.

Hourly -> Value-based pricing rules

Tier	Hourly
Solo freelancer (new)	\$75/h
Established freelancer	\$150/h
Specialist / niche expert	\$300/h
Advisory / fractional	\$500/h

The AI trap: If a client asks "but AI does this for free," respond with: "AI does the draft for free. You're paying me for the judgment - the part that knows which draft to ship, what to leave out, and how to make it sound like you."

Discount policy

If a client says "you used AI, so it should be cheaper," offer a 10% discount on the first project only, with a note: "This is a one-time introduction to working together." Don't repeat it. Clients who will only pay less because of AI are not your clients.

11. Proposal Template (Fill-in-the-Blank)

Copy this and fill in the brackets. Adjust tone to match your voice.

Project: [Project Name]

Prepa

Here's what I heard

[Pain point 1 - direct quote from discovery call]

[Pain point 2 - direct quote or close paraphrase]

[Pain point 3 - direct quote or close paraphrase]

What I'd do

Phase 1 - [Name] (Weeks 1-2)

- [Deliverable 1]
- [Deliverable 2]
- Outcome: [What the client has at the end]

Phase 2 - [Name] (Weeks 3-4)

- [Deliverable 3]
- [Deliverable 4]
- Outcome: [What the client has at the end]

Phase 3 - [Name] (Weeks 5-6)

- [Deliverable 5]
- Outcome: [Final asset / handoff]

Investment

Tier

Price

Starter

	\$[X]
Standard	\$[X]
Premium	\$[X]
Timeline	
Start date: [Date]	Kickoff

Next step

Reply with "go" by [DATE - give them 5-7 business days] and I'll send the contract and invoice. Or book a 30-min scope call: [LINK].

12. 40+ Copy-Paste Prompts (Organized by Function)

All prompts below are written for Copy.ai's chat interface. Adapt to your tool of choice.

LAND (8 prompts)

Cold email sequence (4 emails) - see section 3

LinkedIn DM sequence (4 messages) - see section 3

Proposal template - see section 3

Cold call opener script - see below

Referral request email - see below

Reactivation email to past client - see below

Pricing pushback response - see below

Discovery call question list - see below

Cold call opener

Write a 30-second cold call opener for a freelance [ROLE] calling a

[PRO.

Constraints:

- Open with a specific observation about their company (not flattery).
- State the problem you solve in one sentence.
- Ask a permission-based question: "Do you have 30 seconds for why I'm
- Total under 75 words when spoken.
- Sound like a human, not a script.

calling?&

Referral request

Write a referral request email to a past client who was happy with

[PRO.

Constraints:

- 100-150 words
- Reference the specific project and outcome
- Ask: "Who else do you know who's facing [PROBLEM]?"
- Offer: "If they sign, I'll send you \$[X] or [GIFT] as a thank-you."
- Subject line: NOT "Quick favor"; - use a specific, honest subject.

Pricing pushback

The client said: "[PASTE CLIENT MESSAGE]"

Write a 4-sentence response that:

1. Acknowledges their position without apologizing.
2. Anchors on the outcome, not the hours.
3. Offers two paths: smaller scope at lower price, or full scope at
4. Ends with a single clear question.

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DELIVER (10 prompts)

Research brief - see section 4

Blog post outline (SEO) - see below

Long-form article (1500 words) - see below

Email subject lines (10 variants) - see below

Landing page copy - see below

Sales page copy - see below

Case study draft - see below

Slide deck outline - see below

Script for a 60-second video - see below

Script for a podcast intro - see below

Blog post outline (SEO)

Create a detailed outline for a blog post targeting the keyword

"

Constraints:

- Title (under 60 characters, includes the year 2026 for freshness)
- Meta description (150-160 characters, includes the keyword)
- H1: title
- 5-7 H2 sections, each with 2-4 H3 subpoints
- For each H2: a 1-sentence summary of what the section covers
- 3 internal link opportunities (titles of related posts on the same
- 2 external link opportunities (authoritative sources to cite)
- Comparison table (if applicable)
- FAQ block (3-5 questions, 50-word answers each)
- CTA at the end (newsletter signup or product)

site)

Landing page copy

Write landing page copy for [PRODUCT/SERVICE].

Sections:

- Hero: headline (10 words max), subhead (20 words max), CTA button text
- Problem: 3 bullet points showing the reader's pain
- Solution: 3 bullet points showing how the offer fixes each
- How it works: 3 numbered steps
- Social proof: 2-3 placeholder testimonials (label them as
- Pricing: 3 tiers
- FAQ: 4 questions
- Final CTA: urgency + button

"[T

Tone: [TONE]. Avoid: hype words ("revolutionary," "game-changer"),

Slide deck outline

Create a 12-slide deck outline for a [PRESENTATION TYPE] on [TOPIC] to

For each slide, give: slide title, 3 bullet points (max), and one

Slide 1: Title

BILL (4 prompts)

Late payment sequence (3 emails) - see section 5

Contract red-flag scanner - see below

Scope creep response email - see below

Testimonial request email - see below

Contract red-flag scanner

Review this contract clause and flag anything risky for a freelancer:

Output a table with columns: "Risk," "Why it matters," "Suggested

If the clause is fine, say "No issue."

Scope creep response

The client sent this message asking for something outside our agreed

Write a 4-sentence response that:

1. Confirms I understand the request.
2. Notes that it's outside the original scope.
3. Offers two options: add it as a paid change order, or defer to a future phase.
4. Asks which they'd prefer.

GROW (8 prompts)

LinkedIn carousel (7 slides) - see section 6

Newsletter issue (600 words) - see section 6

LinkedIn post (200 words, hook-first) - see below

X/Twitter thread (7 tweets) - see below

Quote graphic captions (10 variants) - see below

YouTube Shorts script (45-60s) - see below

Lead magnet title + 3-bullet promise - see below

Podcast guest pitch (250 words) - see below

LinkedIn post (200 words)

Write a 200-word LinkedIn post on [TOPIC] for a freelance [ROLE].

Constraints:

- First line is the hook (under 12 words, no "I")
- One specific, defensible opinion in the body
- One short story or example (under 60 words)
- One tactical takeaway the reader can use today
- End with a single question to drive comments
- No "Agree?" or "Thoughts?" as the closer
- No hashtags in the body (add 3-5 at the very end)

X/Twitter thread

Write a 7-tweet thread on [TOPIC] for a freelance [ROLE] audience.

Constraints:

- Tweet 1: hook (under 240 characters, makes a specific promise)
- Tweet 2-6: one idea per tweet, each with a concrete example
- Tweet 7: summary + CTA ("If this was useful, RT tweet 1")
- No tweet starts with "So," "I," or "Here's the thing"

- Each tweet must stand alone if read in isolation
- Total thread: under 1500 characters

YouTube Shorts script

Write a 50-second YouTube Shorts script on [TOPIC] for a freelance

[ROLE]

Constraints:

- Hook in the first 3 seconds (text overlay + spoken)
- 4-5 short beats, each 8-12 seconds
- One specific, defensible opinion
- One concrete example or number
- CTA in the last 5 seconds: "Follow for more [TOPIC]"
- Total spoken word count: 100-120
- Include on-screen text suggestions for each beat

REUSE (5 prompts)

Repurpose long-form -> 10 assets - see section 7

SOP template - see section 7

Case study -> sales page rewrite - see below

Best-of-the-month newsletter - see below

Etsy/Gumroad product outline - see below

Case study -> sales page rewrite

Take this case study: "[PASTE CASE STUDY]"

Rewrite it as a 1-page sales page section with this structure:

- Headline: client's name + the specific result (with a number)
- Subhead: 1 sentence on what the client was struggling with
- 3 bullet points on what we did
- A pull quote (write 3 options, label as "Option A/B/C")
- A short "what this means for you" paragraph
- CTA: book a call

Etsy/Gumroad product outline

I'm turning my expertise in [NICHE] into a digital product for sale on

Etsy a

Output:

- Product name (3 options, max 7 words each)
- 1-sentence tagline
- 3-bullet value promise
- Target buyer (1 sentence)
- Price point (suggest 1 with justification)
- Table of contents (5-8 sections)
- 1 example page or template (write the actual content)
- 1 upsell offer (related product at a higher price)
- 3 social media posts to promote it

Bonus prompts (5 prompts)

"What's the worst that could happen" risk prompt - see below

Hourly rate calibration - see below

Client red flag checklist - see below

Quarterly business review template - see below

Decision journal prompt - see below

Risk prompt

I'm about to [DECISION, e.g., "raise my rates 30% next month"].

Help m

Forces:

- Upside if it works: [LIST]
- Downside if it doesn't: [LIST]
- Reversibility: can I walk this back? How?
- Probability of upside: [YOUR ESTIMATE, low/medium/high]
- Probability of downside: [YOUR ESTIMATE]
- What would have to be true for this to work?

Output: a 200-word analysis and a recommendation.

Client red flag checklist

I'm considering taking on [CLIENT/PROJECT TYPE]. Help me spot red flags.

Checklist (output as a 15-row table):

- "Red flag," "Why it matters," "What to ask before signing"

13. Stack Audit Worksheet (Printable)

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14. When to Add a 6th Tool (and When Not To)

Add a tool when:

- You're using your current tool 5+ times a week and hitting a clear wall
- A new tool will pay for itself in 1-2 months of saved time
- The new tool replaces 2+ existing subscriptions (consolidation, not addition)

Don't add a tool when:

- A Black Friday deal tempts you
- A podcaster you admire mentions it
- Your friend says "you have to try this"
- It's a "platform" that wants to be your homepage (Notion, ClickUp, etc. - pick one, stop switching)

The default answer is no. A freelance stack is a discipline.

15. Appendix: 2026 Pricing Snapshot

Verified July 2026. Always re-check on the tool's site before buying - pricing changes 2-3×/year.

Tool	Tier
Copy.ai	Chat
Copy.ai	Pro
Writesonic	Standard
Writesonic	Professional
Canva	Pro
Canva	Team
Synthesia	Starter

Synthesia

Create

Speechify

AI Stu

Speechify

AI Stu

Bonsai

Solo

Wave

Starte

beehiiv

Free

Gumroad

Free

ChatGPT

Claude

Pro

Free updates for life

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